

A Slice of Egypt

A spiritual leader builds a family of energy-radiating pyramids near Bangalore to give spiritualism a leg-up



THE INDIAN PYRAMID

| By Stephen David |

Egypt's 40-storey-high Great Pyramid, the only standing survivor of the seven wonders of the ancient world, has spawned a clone, albeit a much-smaller one. Just 40 km south of Bangalore at village Kebbedoddi is a 10-storey pyramid which, its creators claim, is a storehouse of energy where people can meditate. Its steel frame is covered with 40,000 cement-tiled murals on all its four sides, each representing the elements of air, water, fire and earth. Created by Brahmarshi Patriji, 63, a former Andhra Pradesh tax inspector who has transformed himself into a spiritual guru, its aim is to "spread the message of meditation, vegetarianism and spiritual science".

The pyramid even boasts of 600 Himalayan crystals that "amplify its energy" and lead to a profounder meditative experience for those who visit its 5,000-seat meditation hall. "It is the world's largest meditation pyramid and our biggest engineering challenge was how to put the cladding," says P.S.R.K. Prasad, trustee of the Pyramid Spiritual Trust (India). Despite its energy-radi-

ating qualities, the superstructure itself has a concrete base and is made of steel with cladding that has artwork.

The Pyramid Valley attracts 'spiritual scientists' and new age speakers from around the world at its annual congress. To add punch to their spiritual thought, Patriji and his core team are now setting up the Maitreya-Buddha Vishwalayam—International Meditation University. Streams and smaller pyramid meditation halls called Tapasthali are coming up in the surrounding hills. Other up-scale plans include more accommodation for visitors in the form of cottages and tents. Despite their association with Buddhism, Pyramid Valley leaders claim their group is non-religious and engaged only in helping people by providing them with physical, mental, and intellectual well-being. Housewife G. Saritha vouches for the experience: "The pyramid radiates energy and the serene atmosphere helps reduce tension in the body."

Patri now plans to lead a team of masters to the Great Pyramid for meditation on a full moon day in September. That would be a thanksgiving to his inspiration. ■